

A big brush

Baleen plates grow in rows from the upper jaw. The stiff hairs act as a filter.

Bubble nets

One way that humpbacks catch their food is by releasing air to make bubble nets. These air cages trap fish and plankton.



A humpback may have 800 baleen plates.

Each humpback has between 10 and 36 throat grooves below its mouth.

Filter facts

- Before birth, baleen whales have tiny tooth buds, but these never develop into teeth.
- Baleen is made of keratin, the same material as human fingernails!
- Just like your fingernails, baleen is constantly growing.